Who Opens the Mail Now?

A guide to the family conversation after Mom is approved.

You handled the application. Your brother visits on Sundays and picks up Mom's mail. Your sister is the one the facility calls. Nobody has said who does what from here.

This guide is for one conversation with one job: write down who opens the mail, who keeps the folder, and who hears about it when something changes. It isn't for deciding what to do about money, or for working out what any letter means.

Who should be there

Mom, if she's up to it. Then everyone who touches her mail, her money or her care: the one who picks up the mail, the one who pays her bills, the one the facility calls, the one who lives far away and phones every night. Someone who can't come can send notes ahead.

Pick one person to take notes. It shouldn't be the person leading the conversation.

How to open

Start with where things stand, and with a question, not an assignment.

- “Mom's Medicaid was approved, and letters are still coming. I'd like us to agree on who opens them and where they go.”
- “Each of us handles a different piece. Can we put the pieces on one page, so everyone knows where to look?”
- Say what the conversation is for: who does what. Say what it isn't for: deciding what to do with Mom's money or property, or working out what Medicaid requires.

Questions to ask

Ask Mom

1. Which parts of this do you want to hear about, and which would you rather one of us handled?

Ask each other

1. Where does Mom's mail go now, and who sees it first?
2. Who opens letters from the Medicaid agency, and how do they let the rest of us know?
3. Where does the folder live, who keeps the calendar of dates from the letters, and who else knows where both are?

4. Who notices when something changes for Mom, such as her room or care, her accounts or her income, and who do they tell?

5. Does anyone know of money that may come to Mom, such as an inheritance, a gift, proceeds from a sale or an insurance payment? Who should hear about it first, so the question gets asked before anyone acts?

6. Who calls the Medicaid agency, and who calls your Medicaid planner, when there's a question?

7. What don't any of us know yet?

How to write down what was said

One line per job. If a job has no name beside it yet, leave it blank instead of volunteering someone who isn't in the room. Where two people remember a letter or a date differently, write both and look at the letter afterward.

THE JOB	WHO	BACKUP	WHERE IT'S KEPT, OR HOW THEY'LL TELL THE REST OF US
Opens letters from the Medicaid agency	David	Karen	Sends a photo of each letter to the family group text
Keeps the folder	Karen		Blue folder, kitchen desk drawer

Questions to carry out of the room

Nobody at the table has to know these answers. Write them down as they are and take them to the Medicaid agency or your Medicaid planner.

- What do we have to do now that Medicaid has approved Mom?
- What changes could affect her eligibility?
- What does keeping her benefits in place involve for our family?

What not to decide yet

These take the Medicaid agency, your Medicaid planner or an elder law attorney, and your notes are what make those conversations useful. Leave them open.

- What to do with any money that has arrived or may arrive.
- Whether a change needs to be reported, or what it means for Mom's Medicaid.
- Anything about gifts, transfers, sales or Mom's legal documents.
- Whose way of handling things was better up to now.

What you can decide today

- Who opens the mail, who keeps the folder, and who keeps the calendar.
- Who takes each open question to the Medicaid agency or your Medicaid planner.
- How you'll let each other know when something changes.
- When you'll talk again.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't resolve a disagreement, decide anything about Mom's money, or tell you what the agency or a professional will say. It gets your family to one page of who does what. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

Your family knows who opens the mail, who keeps the folder and who to tell when something changes. The planning interview asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report that everyone at the table can read and bring to any conversation about paying for Mom's care.

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